> Macmillan was marvellously eloquent in his evocation of British traditions and imperatives and Kennedy greatly liked both Macmillan and David Ormsby-Gore, his ambassador in Washington. But Macmillan could have been dull, and Ormsby-Gore just another diplomat, and the underlying imperative would still have been clear: Nothing could justify this kind of American damage to Anglo-American relations. Kennedy had hoped that Skybolt might still be adequate, but he understood the political problem presented by its damaged reputation. The British must have Polaris.[39]

Another consequence of the Cuban missile crisis concerned public opinion. During the late 1950s and early 1960s anti-nuclear protest had gathered apace, and at one point in 1961 the Labour Party adopted 'unilateral nuclear disarmament'. This augured an unprecedented decision by a nuclear weapons state to cease being a nuclear weapons state. The high tide of 'unilateralism' had already been reached by October 1962. Curiously, perhaps, humanity's proximity to nuclear catastrophe appears to have accelerated the transition from nuclear antipathy to nuclear apathy.[40]

It has been suggested that the missile crisis prompted the build-up of both Soviet strategic nuclear forces and the development of a global role for the Soviet navy. The Soviet deputy foreign minister, Vasily Kuznetsov, remarked to a member of the US delegation at the negotiations in November 1962: 'You Americans will never be able to do this to us again.'[41] His comment is often cited as illustration of the Soviet military response to their retreat and humiliation. There is insufficient evidence that the growth of Soviet strategic forces owed anything to the Caribbean crisis. Khrushchev had previously recognised Soviet quantitative and qualitative inferiority in ICBMs and was already embarked on the expansion of Soviet ICBMs, IRBMs and MRBMs. Leonid Brezhnev shared his aim of achieving military and political parity, though there is no convincing evidence that this was a reaction to Cuba. In other words, for both Moscow and Washington continuing growth of their nuclear arsenals was more a matter of business as usual. In short, as Lebow and Pelopidas observe: